490.LIFE · THE WHOLE STORY · LESSON 25 OF 26

Peter, James, John, and Hebrews

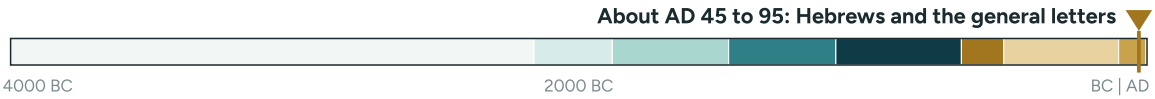
Hebrews; James; 1–2 Peter; 1–3 John; Jude



David S. Jones

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YOU ARE HERE · LESSON 25



Introduction: Letters to Christians Under Pressure

Paul was not the only one who wrote letters to the young churches. Near the end of the New Testament, after Paul's letters, sit eight more: Hebrews, James, 1 and 2 Peter, 1, 2, and 3 John, and Jude. The seven from James to Jude are often called the "general letters," because most of them were written to Christians scattered across many places rather than to one church. Hebrews is sometimes counted with them.

Their writers knew Jesus in the flesh or knew those who did. James and Jude were his younger brothers, sons of Mary and Joseph, who did not believe in him until after the resurrection. Peter denied him three times and was restored. John leaned against him at the Last Supper. The writer of Hebrews, whose name we do not know, heard the gospel from those who had heard the Lord himself (Heb. 2:3).

They wrote to Christians who were tired, pressured, and tempted to give up. Some faced prison and loss of property. Some were tempted to go back to their old religion. Some had a faith that talked well but did nothing. These letters were written from about AD 45 to 95, and they still speak to anyone who is tempted to drift. This lesson walks through them under four headings: Jesus is better (Hebrews), faith that works (James), hope in suffering (Peter), and love and assurance (John), with a short word from Jude at the end.

The Word: Faith

> **Hebrews 11:1, 6** *"Now faith is the assurance of things hoped for, the conviction of things not seen.... And without faith it is impossible to please him, for whoever would draw near to God must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who seek him."*

πίστις *(pistis, "faith")*

trust, reliance, confidence in someone's word

Faith rests

Heb. 12:2

"Looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith." Faith looks away from itself to him.

\+

Faith works

James 2:18

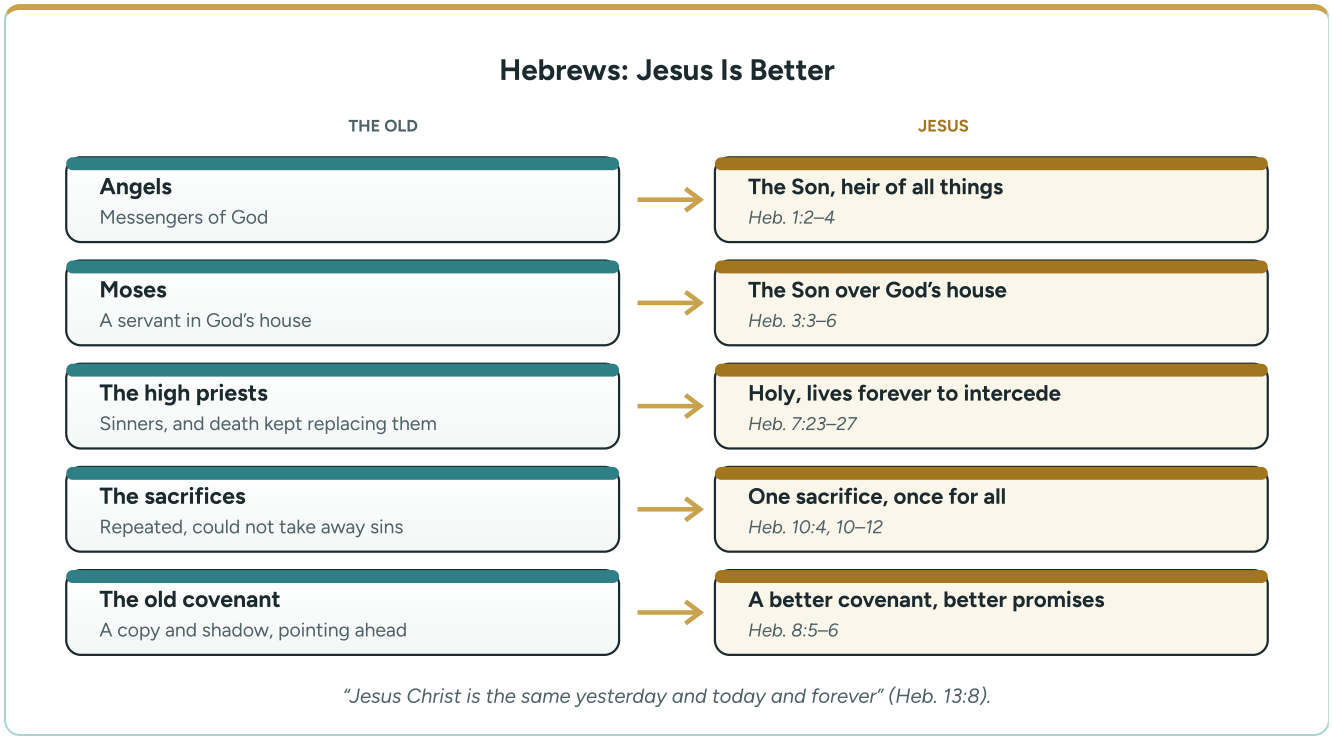
"I will show you my faith by my works." Real trust always shows itself in life.

Payoff: Faith is trust. It is leaning your whole weight on Christ and on what God has promised. Faith is only as good as the one it trusts, so a weak faith in a strong Savior saves, and a strong faith in anything else does not. The Westminster Confession, a summary of Bible teaching written in the 1640s, puts the two sides together. Faith is the only means by which we receive Christ and are declared right with God, yet it never stands alone in the person God has declared righteous. It always comes with every other grace God gives, and it works by love (WCF 11.2).

Part One: Hebrews: Jesus Is Better

Hebrews seems to have been written to Jewish Christians, probably in the 60s, before the temple was destroyed in AD 70. They had suffered for Christ, and now some were tempted to drift back to the temple, the priests, and the sacrifices they had grown up with. The writer answers with one word, repeated again and again: *better*. Why go back to the shadows when you have the real thing?

He begins with who Jesus is. "Long ago, at many times and in many ways, God spoke to our fathers by the prophets, but in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son." The Son "is the radiance of the glory of God and the exact imprint of his nature, and he upholds the universe by the word of his power. After making purification for sins, he sat down at the right hand of the Majesty on high" (1:1–3).



"Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (Heb. 13:8).

Then he shows what Jesus does. Every priest in the temple "stands daily at his service, offering repeatedly the same sacrifices, which can never take away sins." Notice: the priests stood, because their work was never done. "But when Christ had offered for all time a single sacrifice for sins, he sat down at the right hand of God" (10:11–12). He sat down because the work was finished. "For it is impossible for the blood of bulls and goats to take away sins" (10:4), but Christ entered heaven "by means of his own blood, thus securing an eternal redemption" (9:12).

And he is a priest who understands us. "For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but one who in every respect has been tempted as we are, yet without sin. Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace, that we may receive mercy and find grace to help in time of need" (4:15–16). He "always lives to make intercession" for those who come to God through him (7:25).

Hebrews 11 is the great chapter of faith: Abel, Noah, Abraham, Moses, Rahab, and many more, who trusted God's promises before they saw them fulfilled. Then comes the call: "let us run with endurance the race that is set before us, looking to Jesus, the founder and perfecter of our faith, who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross" (12:1–2). Our hope in him is "a sure and steadfast anchor of the soul" (6:19). Storms come, but the anchor holds.

Part Two: James: Faith That Works

This is not the apostle James, the brother of John, who was put to death early on (Acts 12:2). This James was a brother of Jesus. During Jesus' ministry, "not even his brothers believed in him" (John 7:5). After the resurrection Jesus appeared to James (1 Cor. 15:7), and he became a leader of the church in

Jerusalem. His letter, perhaps the earliest book of the New Testament (about AD 45 to 50), is intensely practical and full of commands.

James writes about trials: “Count it all joy, my brothers, when you meet trials of various kinds, for you know that the testing of your faith produces steadfastness” (1:2–3). He writes about the tongue, which is small, but “How great a forest is set ablaze by such a small fire!” (3:5). He writes about pride and plans: “What is your life? For you are a mist that appears for a little time and then vanishes” (4:14). And over it all: “be doers of the word, and not hearers only, deceiving yourselves” (1:22).



“If a brother or sister is poorly clothed and lacking in daily food… what good is that?” (James 2:15–16).

His most famous passage asks a hard question: “What good is it, my brothers, if someone says he has faith but does not have works? Can that faith save him?” Imagine a brother or sister without food or clothes, and you say, “Go in peace, be warmed and filled,” and do nothing. “So also faith by itself, if it does not have works, is dead” (2:14–17).

Then James writes, “You see that a person is justified by works and not by faith alone” (2:24). Does that contradict Paul, who wrote that “one is justified by faith apart from works of the law” (Rom. 3:28)? No. They are fighting different enemies. Paul is answering people who think they can earn God’s acceptance, so he says we are declared righteous by faith alone. James is answering people who claim to have faith but live as if Christ makes no difference, so he says real faith is shown to be real by what it does. James even uses the word “justified” in a different sense. His example is Abraham offering Isaac on the altar (2:21), many years after God had already counted Abraham righteous for believing his promise (Gen. 15:6). Abraham’s obedience did not make him right with God. It showed that he already was. Paul is talking about the root, and James is talking about the fruit. We are saved by faith alone, but the faith that saves is never alone.

Part Three: Peter: Hope in Suffering

The fisherman who once denied Jesus wrote two letters near the end of his life, probably from Rome, about AD 62 to 67. In the first he calls the city "Babylon" (1 Pet. 5:13), the old name of the empire that carried God's people into exile. You will meet that name again in Revelation. He wrote to believers he calls "elect exiles" (1:1), scattered across what is now Turkey, who were being slandered and mistreated for their faith.

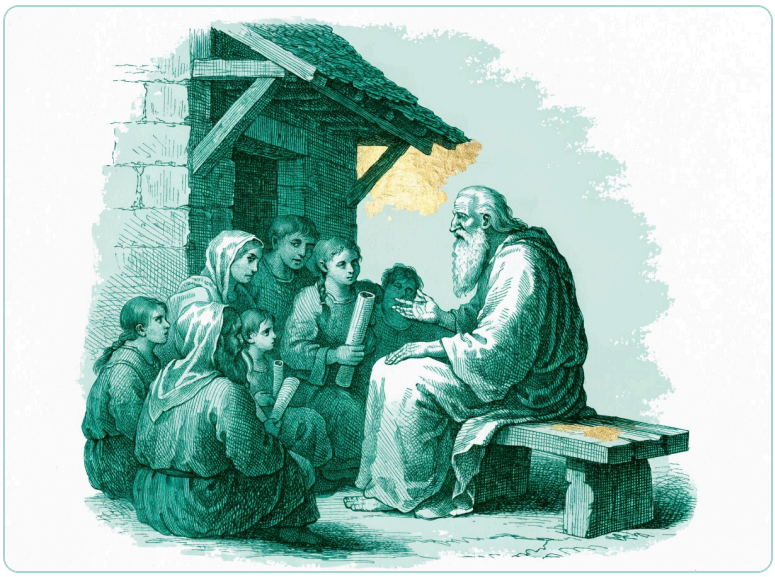
Peter begins with praise: God "has caused us to be born again to a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead, to an inheritance that is imperishable, undefiled, and unfading, kept in heaven for you" (1:3–4). They were exiles on earth, but they had a home that could not be taken from them. Peter, who had once tried to talk Jesus out of the cross, now wrote, "He himself bore our sins in his body on the tree, that we might die to sin and live to righteousness. By his wounds you have been healed" (2:24).

Suffering, Peter says, should not surprise us. "Beloved, do not be surprised at the fiery trial when it comes upon you to test you, as though something strange were happening to you. But rejoice insofar as you share Christ's sufferings" (4:12–13). So while you wait, cast "all your anxieties on him, because he cares for you" (5:7), and always be "prepared to make a defense to anyone who asks you for a reason for the hope that is in you; yet do it with gentleness and respect" (3:15).

In his second letter, written as he knew his death was near, Peter insisted that the gospel was no fairy tale: "we did not follow cleverly devised myths… but we were eyewitnesses of his majesty" (2 Pet. 1:16). If Jesus seems slow to return, it is because God "is patient toward you, not wishing that any should perish, but that all should reach repentance" (3:9). Early Christian writers tell us Peter died for Christ in Rome under Nero, and by about AD 200 they say he was crucified. Jesus had told him long before, "when you are old, you will stretch out your hands," and John adds that this was "to show by what kind of death he was to glorify God" (John 21:18–19).

Part Four: John: Love and Assurance

Early tradition says John was the youngest of the twelve and the last of them to die. In his Gospel he never uses his own name and calls himself the disciple "whom Jesus loved" (John 13:23). The same tradition says he lived to old age in Ephesus, caring for the churches of that region, and wrote his three letters there, probably around AD 85 to 95.



"Beloved, let us love one another, for love is from God" (1 John 4:7).

John writes like a grandfather to "my little children." His themes are simple and deep. God is light (1:5): "If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness" (1:9). And when we fall, "we have an advocate with the Father, Jesus Christ the righteous. He is the propitiation for our sins, and not for ours only but also for the sins of the whole world" (2:1–2). A propitiation is a sacrifice that turns away God's anger against sin. John means there is no other sacrifice for anyone, from any nation, and no one who comes to Christ will find his blood too small for their sin.

God is love (4:8). "In this is love, not that we have loved God but that he loved us and sent his Son to be the propitiation for our sins" (4:10). "See what kind of love the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God; and so we are" (3:1). Love that comes from God flows out to others: "We love because he first loved us" (4:19).

And John wants believers to be sure. False teachers had left the church and unsettled people. So he wrote, "Whoever has the Son has life; whoever does not have the Son of God does not have life. I write these things to you who believe in the name of the Son of God, that you may know that you have eternal life" (5:12–13). That certainty rests on the Son and on God's word about him, not on how strong you feel. John also points to the marks of that life: keeping his commands and loving other believers (2:3; 3:14).

The little letter of Jude, another brother of Jesus, calls believers to "contend for the faith that was once for all delivered to the saints" (Jude 3), and ends with one of the great blessings of the Bible: "Now to him who is able to keep you from stumbling and to present you blameless before the presence of his glory with great joy… be glory" (Jude 24–25).

Hebrews and the General Letters at a Glance

Hebrews *Unknown author · 60s*	Jesus is better: hold on, don't drift	*Heb. 4:14–16*
James *Jesus' brother · about 45–50*	Faith that works	*James 2:17*
1 and 2 Peter *The apostle Peter · about 62–67*	Living hope in suffering	*1 Pet. 1:3*
1, 2, and 3 John *The apostle John · about 85–95*	Love, truth, and assurance	*1 John 5:13*
Jude *Jesus' brother · 60s*	Contend for the faith	*Jude 3*

All dates are approximate. Hebrews names no author.

THREAD WATCH

THE LAMB Peter's brother Andrew heard John the Baptist cry, "Behold, the Lamb of God," and brought Peter to Jesus (John 1:36–42). Years later Peter wrote that we were ransomed "with the precious blood of Christ, like that of a lamb without blemish or spot" (1 Pet. 1:19). Hebrews explains why the old sacrifices were repeated year after year and why Christ's was offered "once for all" (Heb. 10:10).

GOD WITH HIS PEOPLE Only the high priest could pass through the curtain into the Most Holy Place, once a year. Now believers "have confidence to enter the holy places by the blood of Jesus, by the new and living way that he opened for us through the curtain, that is, through his flesh" (Heb. 10:19–20). The way into God's presence is open.

The Turn: Draw Near

Each of these letters was written to people tempted to drift, from Christ, from his people, or into a faith that did nothing. Maybe that is you. Hebrews says, "how shall we escape if we neglect such a great salvation?" (2:3). Drifting is not neutral. A boat without an anchor does not stay where it is. Christ never lets go of those who are truly his, and warnings like this are one of the ways he keeps them. His people hear the warning and hold on: "we are his house, if indeed we hold fast our confidence and our boasting in our hope" (3:6).

But the invitation is greater than the warning. "Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace, that we may receive mercy and find grace to help in time of need" (Heb. 4:16). You do not come to a God who is waiting to crush you. You come to a throne of grace, through a High Priest who knows your weakness and has already paid for your sin.

If you have never trusted Christ, trust him today. He "suffered once for sins, the righteous for the unrighteous, that he might bring us to God" (1 Pet. 3:18). If you have, confess your sins and believe that he forgives them. Let your faith show itself in love. And rest in this: whoever has the Son has life, and you may know it.

Living It: Six Practices for This Week

1. **Read the short letters.** Read James and 1 John this week. Each takes about fifteen minutes.
2. **Draw near.** Bring one specific weakness or need to Christ in prayer, using Hebrews 4:15–16.
3. **Do the word.** Pick one command from James and obey it this week.
4. **Meet a need.** Like the picture in James 2, give food, clothes, or help to someone in need.
5. **Be ready.** Write out in a few sentences the reason for the hope that is in you (1 Pet. 3:15).
6. **Memorize Hebrews 4:16.** "Let us then with confidence draw near to the throne of grace, that we may receive mercy and find grace to help in time of need."

Before Lesson 26: *Read Revelation 1:9–18, 4–5, and 21:1–22:5. Lesson 26 ends the series with Revelation and the new creation.*

For Discussion

1. Hebrews says Jesus is better than angels, Moses, the priests, and the sacrifices. Which of these comparisons helps you most?
2. Why does it matter that the priests stood but Christ sat down?
3. How would you explain to a friend how Paul and James fit together on faith and works?
4. James says the tongue is like a small fire. Where do you see that in your own life?
5. Peter says not to be surprised by suffering. Why do Christians so often feel surprised?
6. John writes so that believers may know they have eternal life. Is that kind of certainty proud or humble? Why?
7. Which of these letters do you most need to read this month? Why?

Sources & For Further Study

- On faith and works: Westminster Confession of Faith 11 and 14; Westminster Shorter Catechism 86.
- On perseverance and assurance: Westminster Confession of Faith 17 and 18.
- On Hebrews: Richard D. Phillips, *Hebrews* (Reformed Expository Commentary); F. F. Bruce, *The Epistle to the Hebrews*.
- On the general letters: Douglas J. Moo, *The Letter of James*; Edmund P. Clowney, *The Message of 1 Peter*; John Stott, *The Letters of John*.



David S. Jones

Author of *Seventy Times Seven: On the God Who Forgives Past All Counting*. He teaches Scripture every week or so at 490.life, serves on the worship teams at Scottsdale Bible Church, and serves in the men's group, The Forge, helping to disciple men and pointing them to Jesus. He coaches and mentors men one-to-one and speaks to churches and men's groups.

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